Shazlo design and planning docs

Status	Draft v1.0 for team review
Date	2026-10-19
Audience	The three engineers, the founders and ops, anyone joining the team

These documents describe who Shazlo is for, how users move through it, how the system fits together (customer app, vendor portal, admin, website, and the two backend services), the database, and the API. They separate what ships by **Oct 30** (the MVP) from the **target** architecture, and they say what is still undecided.

Start here

architecture.md is the authoritative, production-grade architecture document (system design picture, technology map, service boundary, data, integration, flows, consistency, security, operations, deployment, scale, cost, testing, roadmap). The numbered documents below go deeper on one topic each and are aligned to it.

Read in this order

#	Document	What it answers
-	Architecture	The whole system in one document, with the technology map and the production concerns
01	Personas	Who are the customers, vendors and internal users, and what do they need?
02	User flows	How does each persona move through the product? What are the states of vendors, products, orders and payments?
03	System architecture	What runs where, how modules relate, security, deployment, scale
04	Database design	The list of all 58 tables and their indexes, in two databases
04b	Database notes	Design rules, cross-database references, vectors, migration from today's tables, Redis keys, personal data, MVP delta
05	API design	GraphQL schema for the app, REST for vendor, public, admin and webhooks, errors, limits
06	MVP slice and migration	Exactly what is built by Oct 30 on today's backend, and how it migrates to the new server
07	Website audit and plan	What is wrong with the marketing site, and what to fix
08	Service split	Core and Vendor-admin: the boundary rule, what changed in the redraw, builder checklist
-	Open questions	Decisions the team still has to make, each with a default
-	Decision records	Why the big choices were made

Decision records

ADR	Decision	Status
0001	Modular monolith with service and selector layers (now inside each service)	Accepted, amended by 0007

ADR	Decision	Status
0002	GraphQL for the app, REST for the rest; MVP on REST	Proposed
0003	pgvector in Postgres instead of Pinecone	Accepted
0004	Own JWT with guest accounts	Accepted (target)
0005	Cloudinary now, object storage and CDN later	Accepted (MVP)
0006	Order requests and manual settlement at launch; online payments built behind a switch	Accepted (MVP), amended
0007	Two services: Core (Django) and Vendor-admin (FastAPI)	Accepted (direction), amended by 0008
0008	Commerce (cart, checkout, orders, stock, payments) lives in Core; vendor-admin is the seller back-office	Accepted

Legend

Tag	Meaning
`[As-is]`	True today, verified in the code or the website source
`[MVP]`	Built by the Oct 30 freeze on today's Django backend
`[Target]`	The design for the new server (`shazlo-server`)
`[Assumption]`	A proposal or guess that needs a team decision (see `open-questions.md`)

Shared vocabulary

Term	Meaning
Guest	A user created automatically on first launch, with no sign-up; becomes a customer by upgrading the same account
Core service, vendor-admin service	The two backends: Core is the Django service for customers **and commerce** (cart, checkout, orders, stock, payments); the vendor-admin service is the FastAPI seller back-office (vendors, catalog authoring, fulfilment screens, statements, admin)
Customer, vendor owner, vendor staff, admin	The roles in `03` section 6
Vendor	A brand or boutique that lists and fulfils products (the `Brand` model today)
Embedding	512 numbers describing how a product looks, made by the image model
Taste vector	512 numbers describing what a user likes, updated by each swipe
Slate	One batch of 10 products: 7 from the user's strongest category and 3 from others
Order request	The MVP order: placed by the customer, confirmed by the vendor, paid in cash or UPI on delivery
MVP slice	The part of the target built on today's backend by Oct 30
Target	The new server's architecture, built after launch

Conventions used across the documents

- Roles: `guest`, `customer`, `vendor_owner`, `vendor_staff`, `admin`.

- Enumerations (vendor, product, order, payment, swipe action) are listed once in `04` section 4 and reused everywhere.
- Money is an integer number of paise; time is UTC; ids are UUIDs.
- Code lives in two repositories (`shaz` for the app and core backend; the portal repo for the vendor frontend, the vendor-admin backend and the contracts), see `architecture.md` section 10.2.
- Diagrams are Mermaid text, so they render in most repository viewers and are reviewed in pull requests.

External references

These documents grew out of earlier working documents, which live outside this repository:

- **Shazlo Production Architecture Plan** (a longer plan, with the full target architecture).
- **Shazlo Production Readiness Plan** with a **Bug register** tab. Register ids such as `SEC-01` or `AI-08` quoted in `06` refer to that tab.

Maintaining these docs

- Change a document in a pull request, with a one-line note at the top of the document's table when a decision changes.
- When a question in `open-questions.md` is decided, write the answer there, update the affected document and, for a bigger choice, add an ADR.
- Keep names (roles, enums, paths, tables) identical across documents; a mismatch is a bug.
- Owners for each document are to be assigned; until then the engineer who changes the area updates the document.

Changelog

Date	Change
2026-10-19	First draft of all documents
2026-10-19	v0.2: vendor and admin split into a FastAPI marketplace service (new `08`, ADR 0007; `03` to `06` carry pointers and corrections)
2026-10-19	v0.3: team answers recorded (`open-questions.md`): two databases, outbox events, React portal, SQLAdmin, 15% commission, one-VM hosting, two repositories, online payments behind a switch
2026-10-20	v1.0: **new master `architecture.md`**; the service boundary is corrected (commerce, stock and Razorpay in Core; the FastAPI service renamed vendor-admin and limited to the seller back-office; ADR 0008); docs 01 to 08 rewritten to match